

# Baja Beachhead: Feature Strategy

US & Canadian owners renting in Todos Santos · Los Cabos · La Paz

Narrowing the launch to US/Canadian homeowners who own and rent property in Baja California Sur sharpens the product. These owners already rent on Airbnb and build a base of return guests — the perfect direct-booking candidate — but the cross-border nature of their business creates friction Airbnb papers over. That friction is exactly where Familiar Guest can win.

The **core insight**: for this segment, the differentiators are not generic booking features — they are **cross-border** features: money that moves cleanly between countries, trust strong enough to send a deposit abroad, two languages, and tools for owners who run their home from 2,000 miles away.

## Market Analysis: The Baja California Sur Corridor

The three towns form a single, connected second-home market on the southern tip of the Baja peninsula:

| Town                                           | Character                                                            | Owner & guest profile                                                   |
|------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Los Cabos (Cabo San Lucas + San José del Cabo) | Established resort market, highest rental rates, large STR inventory | Heavy US/Canadian ownership; mix of resort tourists and repeat visitors |
| La Paz                                         | State capital, authentic, growing, calmer waterfront                 | More long-stay and value-oriented; growing expat base                   |
| Todos Santos                                   | Pueblo Mágico — artsy, boutique, fast-growing, high-end              | Dense US/Canadian second-home ownership; design-conscious return guests |

Todos Santos sits roughly an hour north of Cabo San Lucas and an hour southwest of La Paz — the three are a natural cluster to serve as one beachhead.

**Nov–Apr**  
HIGH SEASON (SNOWBIRDS, WHALES, ESCAPING THE COLD)

**Weeks–months**  
TYPICAL SNOWBIRD STAY LENGTH

**US · CA · MX**  
GUEST ORIGINS TO SERVE IN TWO LANGUAGES

**Why these owners are ready to go direct**: they already have a season of repeat guests, they feel Airbnb's ~15.5% fee acutely on high-value bookings, and many already coordinate informally (email, WhatsApp) with

returning guests. They need a trustworthy way to take that relationship direct — without becoming a tech company.

## The Cross-Border Realities That Drive Features

| Reality                         | Consequence                                                                                                                                       | Feature opportunity                                              |
|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Money crosses borders           | Guests pay USD/CAD/MXN; owners often want USD payout to a US/Canada bank while the home is in Mexico. FX and payout control are real pain.        | Multi-currency pricing + flexible cross-border payouts           |
| Foreign ownership = fideicomiso | Coastal property (within ~50 km of shore) is held by foreigners via a bank trust ( <i>fideicomiso</i> ) or Mexican corporation, not direct title. | Ownership verification that accepts fideicomiso / corp documents |
| Taxes get complex going direct  | Airbnb auto-withholds Mexican ISR/IVA for hosts. Direct, the owner inherits ISR, IVA, and the BCS lodging tax (ISH), plus US/Canada reporting.    | Cross-border income & tax helper (with strong caveats)           |
| Snowbird stays are long         | Many guests stay weeks to months in high season.                                                                                                  | Weekly/monthly rates + installment payments                      |
| Owners are absentee             | They live in the US/Canada; the home runs on local caretakers and cleaners.                                                                       | Caretaker role + remote/digital check-in                         |
| Two languages                   | Owners are English-first; many guests (esp. Mexican nationals) are Spanish-first.                                                                 | Bilingual booking page + AI-translated messaging                 |
| Real infrastructure quirks      | Baja homes deal with water delivery/cisterns, blackouts, dirt/4x4 roads.                                                                          | Baja-specific house-manual templates                             |

## Recommended Features — Stack-Ranked for This Beachhead

Scored for the Baja segment: **Owner value** · **Guest value** · **Differentiation** · **Probability of success**. Tags mark whether each is **NEW** versus an extension of the existing roadmap.

### 1. Multi-Currency Pricing & Cross-Border Payouts **NEW**

Show prices in the guest's currency (USD/CAD/MXN); let the owner choose payout currency and destination bank (US, Canada, or Mexico). Transparent FX, no surprises.

**Why #1:** this is *the* defining cross-border feature. Airbnb gives owners almost no control here and poor effective FX. Solving clean, predictable money movement between three countries is the single biggest reason this segment would switch — and Stripe Connect supports the rails.

### 2. Bilingual Booking & AI-Translated Messaging **NEW**

English/Spanish booking pages and guest communication, with AI translating messages both ways in real time.

**Why #2:** it instantly widens the guest base to Mexican nationals (a large, underserved direct-booking audience) while serving US/Canadian guests, and it removes the language barrier for absentee English-speaking owners. Cheap to build with AI, hard for a casual owner to do alone.

### 3. Cross-Border Trust Stack, Led Hard **NEW** emphasis

Escrow + Verified Owner + Truvi screening/damage coverage — packaged and messaged specifically as *"safe to book a home in Mexico."* (Truvi supports Mexico, unlike US-only Safely/Waivo.)

**Why #3:** the #1 emotional barrier to direct booking abroad is "am I wiring money to a stranger in another country?" Escrow (funds held until check-in) is the perfect antidote, and damage coverage is actually available in Mexico through Truvi. This is positioning as much as product.

4. Snowbird Long-Stay Support & Installments NEW

Weekly and monthly rates, plus the ability to pay a deposit now and the balance before arrival (and optionally split a long stay into installments).

**Why #4:** the Nov–Apr guest often stays weeks or months. Long-stay pricing and installments fit the actual booking behavior of this corridor and reduce friction on large reservations. Builds on the earlier "pay-in-two" idea, now segment-justified.

5. Remote-Owner Operations: Caretaker Role + Digital Check-In NEW

A limited-access role for the local cleaner/caretaker (see bookings, check-in dates, prep tasks) plus digital check-in instructions and lockbox/smart-code support.

**Why #5:** these owners are not on-site. The home runs on local help and self-check-in. Giving the caretaker a scoped view — without exposing payments or the guest list — matches how the business actually operates.

6. Baja House Manual Templates + Season-Timed Re-Invite NEW + extends roadmap

Pre-built local house-manual sections (water/cistern, drinking water, power/blackouts, 4x4 roads, nearest town, emergency contacts, useful Spanish phrases) and a re-invite that fires in Sept–Oct for the coming high season.

**Why #6:** delightful and cheap. The local-knowledge templates save absentee owners real effort and reduce guest questions; the season-timed re-invite (an extension of past-guest import) turns the predictable Nov–Apr rhythm into repeat bookings.

7. Cross-Border Income & Tax Helper NEW

Income reporting that separates US/Canada reporting (e.g., Schedule E) from Mexican obligations (ISR, IVA, ISH lodging tax), with a clear lodging-tax line item per booking.

**Why #7 (and last):** genuinely valuable — losing Airbnb's automatic tax withholding is a real worry for these owners — but it's liability-sensitive and complex. Ship informational support with firm "not tax advice" guardrails; do not over-promise. Lower near-term probability than the rest.

Summary Scorecard

| Rank | Feature                               | Owner value | Guest value | Differentiation | Probability |
|------|---------------------------------------|-------------|-------------|-----------------|-------------|
| 1    | Multi-currency + cross-border payouts | ●●●●●       | ●●●●○       | ●●●●●           | ●●●●○       |
| 2    | Bilingual booking + AI translation    | ●●●●○       | ●●●●●       | ●●●●●           | ●●●●○       |
| 3    | Cross-border trust stack              | ●●●●●       | ●●●●●       | ●●●●○           | ●●●●○       |

|   |                                   |           |           |           |           |
|---|-----------------------------------|-----------|-----------|-----------|-----------|
| 4 | Long-stay + installments          | ● ● ● ● ○ | ● ● ● ● ○ | ● ● ● ○ ○ | ● ● ● ● ● |
| 5 | Caretaker role + digital check-in | ● ● ● ● ● | ● ● ● ○ ○ | ● ● ● ● ○ | ● ● ● ● ○ |
| 6 | Baja manual + season re-invite    | ● ● ● ● ○ | ● ● ● ● ○ | ● ● ● ○ ○ | ● ● ● ● ● |
| 7 | Cross-border tax helper           | ● ● ● ● ○ | ● ● ○ ○ ○ | ● ● ● ● ○ | ● ● ○ ○ ○ |

## How This Re-Prioritizes the Earlier Top-5

The five general features still hold, but the beachhead changes their order and framing:

- **Past-guest import (was #1)** — still essential; now paired with the **season-timed re-invite** for the Nov-Apr rhythm.
- **AI Concierge (was #2)** — folds into **bilingual AI messaging**; translation becomes its highest-value job here.
- **Double-booking radar (was #3)** — still valuable; matters most for owners cross-listing on Airbnb + VRBO.
- **Owner-owned reviews (was #4)** — useful, but lower priority than the cross-border essentials for launch.
- **Pay-in-two (was #5)** — promoted into **long-stay + installments**, now justified by snowbird behavior.

## Risks & Honest Caveats

**Tax and legal items need professional verification.** Mexican rental taxation (ISR, IVA, ISH), fideicomiso rules, and US/Canada cross-border reporting are summarized here at a strategic level. Confirm specifics with a cross-border tax attorney and Mexican counsel before building owner-facing tax features or making compliance claims. Familiar Guest should inform, not advise.

- **Regulatory exposure.** Short-term rental rules in BCS municipalities can change; lodging-tax handling must be correct.
- **Payment complexity.** Cross-border payouts and FX add Stripe configuration and support overhead — worth validating early with one real owner.
- **Infrastructure reality.** Water and power constraints in towns like Todos Santos are real (confirmed in public sources) — set guest expectations in the house manual, don't hide them.

## Sources & Method

*Market structure, seasonality, and cross-border regulatory shape are drawn from domain knowledge and public reference material (including the Todos Santos public profile, which confirms its Los Cabos/La Paz*

*positioning and documented water/power infrastructure strain). Live web search was unavailable in this session, so quantitative market figures are intentionally given as ranges/directional and should be validated against current STR market data (e.g., AirDNA for Los Cabos/BCS) and professional tax/legal counsel before planning decisions.*

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